Motivation

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Motivation

Purpose of this chapter

The Motivation chapter explains why the SAF exists. It also explains why architecture decisions in an NSI are taken the way they are. It records the forces that act on statistical organisations, the results they want to achieve, the rules that guide their decisions, and the parties whose concerns must be addressed.

Without an explicit motivation, architecture is a set of models without a reason. With it, every capability, process, data state, application or platform choice can be traced back to a need and a result. That traceability makes architecture defensible, whether in a governance board, a budget discussion or an international review.

Position in the framework

Motivation is the first layer of the SAF and the foundation for the other layers. The Strategy layer translates motivation into capabilities and value streams. The architecture domains (business, data, application and technology) then translate strategy into design.

The SAF is structured according to TOGAF and modelled in ArchiMate. The figure below shows how the phases of the TOGAF Architecture Development Method (ADM) relate to the ArchiMate layers. The figure has three areas:

- **Strategy & Motivation:** the Preliminary Phase, Phase A (Architecture Vision), and Requirements Management.
- **Core layers:** Phases B, C, and D, which produce the Business, Application (Information Systems), and Technology architectures.
- **Implementation & Migration:** Phases E to H, which plan, govern, and change the realisation of the architecture.

PLACEHOLDER: Logical model of the different layers to be added

The Motivation layer sits in the Strategy & Motivation area, at the start of the ADM cycle. It holds the content that TOGAF produces before any architecture domain is designed. That content keeps steering the architecture in all later phases.

ADM phase	Role of motivation in this phase	SAF sections
Preliminary	Establish the architecture capability: who the architecture serves and which rules guide decisions	Stakeholders, Architecture Principles
A. Architecture Vision	Explain why change is needed, what must be achieved and what value it brings	Drivers, Goals, Outcomes, Meaning, Value
Requirements Management	Turn goals into requirements and constraints, and keep them traceable through every phase	Requirements, Constraints
B, C, D. Core architectures	Justify design choices in business, application and technology architecture	Traceability from each design decision back to a goal and a driver

ADM phase	Role of motivation in this phase	SAF sections
E to H. Implementation & Migration	Prioritise solutions and work packages; reassess when drivers change	Drivers and goals as criteria for prioritisation and change requests

Three consequences follow from this position.

- **Motivation comes first.** In TOGAF, no architecture domain is designed until stakeholders, drivers, goals and principles are agreed. The SAF follows the same order. Every later element must be traceable to the motivation.
- **Motivation stays active throughout the cycle.** Requirements Management sits at the centre of the ADM. Goals are refined into requirements there, and those requirements are checked in every phase. Motivation is the reference against which each architecture decision is tested, not a one-off introduction.
- **Motivation closes the loop.** In Phase H (Architecture Change Management), a new or changed driver triggers a change request. Examples are a new regulation or a new data source. The cycle then returns to the Preliminary Phase or Phase A, and the motivation elements become the starting point of the next iteration.

The Strategy layer shares the Strategy & Motivation area with the Motivation layer. Motivation explains *why*. Strategy describes *what* the NSI must be able to do (capabilities) and *how* it creates value (value streams). Strategy is the bridge to Phase B, Business Architecture.

How NSIs use this chapter

The motivation elements in this chapter are a reference set. They describe internal and external forces and intentions that most NSIs share. Modelling the motivation layer is not mandatory, but the SAF strongly recommends it.

Most NSIs have a motivation, but it is implicit. It lives in strategy documents, board decisions and the experience of staff. It is rarely written down in a way that connects it to architecture decisions. Making it explicit, in SAF terms, helps an NSI in four ways.

First, it justifies investment. If every programme can be traced to a driver and a goal, an investment proposal rests on shared reasoning, not on individual preference. Boards and ministries can see what a proposal responds to, and what is at stake if it is not funded. The same links help to set priorities. Work that addresses several drivers, or contributes to a key outcome, comes before work that addresses none.

Second, it makes decisions consistent. Principles are derived from the motivation and turn intentions into decision rules. Similar questions then get similar answers, whichever team or architect is involved. When circumstances change, for example through new legislation, the documented links show which goals, principles and capabilities are affected. The NSI can review those specific decisions instead of starting over.

Third, it preserves knowledge. Staff move on and projects end. A documented motivation keeps the reasoning behind past decisions available. New statisticians and IT specialists can see why the architecture looks the way it does.

Fourth, it supports collaboration between NSIs. When NSIs use the same concepts and identifiers, they can quickly see where their interests overlap. That makes it easier to start joint projects, share components and compare approaches. A documented motivation is also useful evidence in external assessments, such as peer reviews.

An NSI can use each SAF motivation element in one of three ways: 1. **Adopt.** Use an SAF element as is, when it matches the national situation. 2. **Adapt.** Refine an SAF element with national specifics, such as a national statistics act or a government-wide digital strategy. 3. **Extend.** Add elements that are specific to the NSI, while keeping a reference to the closest SAF element where one exists.

PLACEHOLDER: Maturity Assessement to be added to the toolkit

Motivation concepts in the SAF

SAF section	ArchiMate element	Question it answers	Identifier
Drivers	Driver	Which forces make change necessary?	SAF-D
Goals	Goal	What does the NSI intend to achieve?	SAF-G
Meaning	Meaning	What does the framework signify to its users?	SAF-M
Outcomes	Outcome	Which concrete results show that a goal is achieved?	SAF-O
Architecture Principles	Principle	Which rules guide architecture decisions?	SAF-P
Value	Value	What is the framework worth, and to whom?	SAF-V
Assessment	Assessment	What does a driver mean for this NSI?	*TBD by NSI*
Requirements	Requirement	What must a solution do or provide to realise a goal?	*TBD by NSI*
Constraints	Constraint	Which limits apply to the design or its realisation?	*TBD by NSI*
Stakeholders	Stakeholder	Whose concerns must the architecture address?	SAF-ST

The concepts form a chain. Stakeholders have concerns about drivers. An assessment records what a driver means for one NSI. Drivers motivate goals. Outcomes make goals measurable. Principles guide how goals are pursued, and requirements and constraints make them concrete for a solution. Meaning and value express why the result matters to stakeholders.

Drivers

The concept

A **driver** is an external or internal condition that motivates an organisation to set goals and to change. A driver is a force, not a problem and not a solution. “Rapid technological change” is a driver. “Our methods cannot use administrative data” is an assessment of that driver for one NSI. “Integrate new data sources into production” is a goal.

Three characteristics set drivers apart from other motivation elements:

- **They exist independently of the NSI.** An NSI can respond to a driver, but cannot decide whether it exists.
- **They are external or internal.** External drivers come from the environment: technology, legislation, society, politics or the economy. Internal drivers come from within: legacy systems, skills or organisational structure.
- **They are relatively stable.** A driver usually stays relevant for several years. Short-lived events, such as an incident or a budget round, are better recorded as assessments.

How the SAF applies drivers

Why the SAF records drivers

Drivers make the SAF a response to real pressures instead of an abstract ideal. With them, an NSI can explain to its board, its ministry or a peer review why change is needed, and what happens without it. Drivers also help to set priorities. An investment that responds to several drivers deserves more attention than one that responds to none.

How drivers fit into an NSI's own architecture

The SAF drivers are common to the UNECE statistical community. An NSI applies them in four steps:

1. **Recognise.** Decide which SAF drivers apply to the national situation, and add national drivers where needed.
2. **Assess.** Analyse what each driver means for the NSI: strengths, weaknesses, risks and opportunities.
3. **Respond.** Derive or confirm the goals that answer the assessed drivers.
4. **Trace.** Link capabilities, programmes and architecture decisions to the drivers they address.

Relationships with other concepts

Related concept	Relationship	Example in the SAF
Stakeholders (SAF-ST)	Stakeholders have concerns about drivers and often raise them	CIOs and CTOs (SAF-ST01) raise resource constraints (SAF-D5)
Assessment	An assessment records what a driver means for one NSI	"Two thirds of our processing runs on platforms out of vendor support" assesses SAF-D5
Goals (SAF-G)	Drivers motivate goals	Resource constraints (SAF-D5) motivate cost efficiency (SAF-G1)
Principles (SAF-P)	Drivers explain why a principle exists	Trust and data protection (SAF-D3) explain privacy by design (SAF-P11)
Capabilities (Strategy)	Capabilities are developed in response to drivers, through goals	AI and technological acceleration (SAF-D2) drives investment in methodology (capability 2.2.3)
Value streams (Strategy)	Value streams show where a driver affects the production chain	Evolving data ecosystems (SAF-D1) affect data acquisition (VS-01)

SAF drivers

ID	Driver	Type	Description	Architectural response in the SAF
SAF-D1	Evolving data ecosystems and partnerships	External	Statistics no longer rely on surveys alone. They draw on administrative, commercial, platform and community data. This creates opportunities, but also dependencies on actors outside the NSI's control.	Secure data sharing, standard interfaces, open-source collaboration and transparent governance, so that NSIs can take part in national data platforms and European data spaces.

ID	Driver	Type	Description	Architectural response in the SAF
SAF-D2	Artificial intelligence and technological acceleration	External	AI, automation and fast technological change alter how data is created, processed and used. NSIs must adopt these technologies and make their own outputs AI-ready.	A risk-based approach: tight control of methodologically critical processes, more automation where risk is lower. Modular, standards-based design to adopt new technology at a controlled pace.
SAF-D3	Trust, scientific rigour and data protection	External	Misinformation, privacy concerns and unregulated data providers put public confidence under pressure. Trust needs more than compliance. It needs rigour, transparency and accountability.	Protection built into the design: confidentiality controls, methodological integrity, traceability, and oversight in proportion to sensitivity.
SAF-D4	Uncertain and polarised global environment	External	Global tensions and political polarisation affect how official statistics are demanded and perceived. Cross-border data flows require openness and interoperability.	Interoperable architectures based on shared standards. Design principles that protect independence, comparability and credibility.
SAF-D5	Resource constraints and organisational agility	Internal and external	Budgets are tight, systems are ageing and specialist skills are scarce. Demand for timely and detailed output keeps growing.	Modular design, shared services, reuse and step-by-step modernisation, so that capacity can be shifted without large reinvestment.

Driver details

SAF-D1 Evolving data ecosystems and partnerships

Official statistics are moving from isolated data collection to a wider data ecosystem. Surveys used to be the main source. Now they sit next to administrative, commercial, platform and community data. This opens up new forms of collaboration. It also makes NSIs dependent on actors, technologies and infrastructures they do not control.

Open source is part of this ecosystem. It gives NSIs a shared base for innovation, transparency and lower costs. NSIs can develop tools and methods together with peers, academia and private partners.

The SAF responds with architectures for secure data sharing, standard interfaces and transparent governance. These let NSIs take part in national data platforms and European data spaces, where production may span several environments and jurisdictions. Openness is combined with strong governance and clear accountability, so that collaboration does not compromise the integrity of official statistics.

SAF-D2 Artificial intelligence and technological acceleration

AI, automation and rapid technological progress are changing how data is created, processed and used. New tools can automate routine tasks, improve analysis and strengthen quality assurance. They also raise the question of what relevant and trusted statistics mean when users rely on intelligent systems.

NSIs must both use AI and make their outputs usable by AI. Internally, that requires architectures and skills for automation, machine learning and advanced analytics, within secure and transparent limits. Externally, statistics must be machine-readable, machine-understandable and interoperable with the platforms that policy makers, researchers and citizens use.

The SAF takes a risk-based approach. Processes that demand methodological rigour and control stay tightly governed. Less sensitive areas can be automated further. Modular, standards-based design lets an NSI adopt new technology at its own pace, while it stays fully accountable for quality, data protection and independence.

SAF-D3 Trust, scientific rigour and data protection

Trust is the basis of official statistics. Misinformation, privacy concerns and unregulated data providers put it under pressure. Compliance alone does not maintain public confidence. Scientific rigour, transparency and clear accountability for the handling of data are also needed.

The SAF builds trust and protection into the architecture. It promotes governance and technical controls that protect confidentiality, keep methods sound and make processes traceable. Oversight is strict where sensitivity and quality demands are high. Where risks are lower, more automation and shared solutions are possible.

SAF-D4 Uncertain and polarised global environment

Global tensions, political polarisation and shifting power relations affect how official statistics are demanded and perceived. At the same time, cross-border data flows require statistical systems to stay open and interoperable, without giving up national and institutional integrity.

The SAF offers a stable base for cooperation. Interoperable architectures based on shared standards let NSIs exchange data and methods securely. Design principles that protect independence and transparency help NSIs stay credible and comparable, even when facts themselves are contested.

SAF-D5 Resource constraints and organisational agility

Many NSIs must do more with limited budgets, ageing systems and a shortage of specialist staff. Demand for timely, detailed and cross-domain output keeps growing. Meeting that demand requires efficiency and the ability to adapt quickly.

The SAF makes flexibility and reuse core principles. It supports modular design, shared services and scalable solutions that reduce duplication. Clear governance of priorities lets NSIs shift capacity, modernise step by step and keep delivering quality output under financial and staffing pressure.

PLACEHOLDER: Drivers Template and Application of Drivers to be added to the toolkit

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Goals

The concept

A goal is a statement of intent. It is the direction or end state an organisation wants to achieve. A goal says *what* the organisation wants to achieve. It does not say *how*, or *how much*.

Three characteristics set goals apart:

- **They are qualitative and directional.** "Modernise statistical systems" sets a direction. A measurable result, such as "retire all platforms out of vendor support by 2029", is an outcome.
- **They are long-term.** A goal usually spans several planning cycles and outlives individual programmes and projects.
- **They are owned by stakeholders.** A goal only has meaning if a stakeholder recognises it as their intention.

The SAF goals cover operational and strategic needs. Some focus on efficiency, modernisation and compliance, which keep an NSI sustainable. Others support innovation and collaboration, such as the use of new data sources or advanced analytics. Together these goals make sure that modernisation does not weaken the core values of official statistics: neutrality, accuracy and reliability.

How the SAF applies goals

Why the SAF records goals

Goals define what success looks like, for the SAF and for the NSIs that apply it. They give direction to the Strategy layer: capabilities and value streams are developed because they contribute to a goal. Without explicit goals, modernisation can turn into a series of technical upgrades that nobody can explain.

How goals fit into an NSI's own architecture

The SAF goals are shared by the UNECE statistical community. An NSI relates them to its own strategic plan. It then translates each relevant goal into measurable outcomes and, where needed, into objectives for programmes and projects. Goals that matter nationally but have no SAF counterpart are added as national goals. Each NSI can follow this path at its own pace, while working towards the same shared direction.

Relationships with other concepts

Related concept	Relationship	Example in the SAF
Drivers (SAF-D)	Drivers motivate goals	Resource constraints (SAF-D5) motivate cost efficiency (SAF-G1)
Outcomes (SAF-O)	Outcomes make goals measurable	Increased efficiency (SAF-O5) shows progress on cost efficiency (SAF-G1)
Principles (SAF-P)	Principles guide how goals are pursued	Reuse before buying (SAF-P01) guides how cost efficiency is achieved
Stakeholders (SAF-ST)	Stakeholders own goals	CIOs and CTOs (SAF-ST01) own modernisation (SAF-G3)
Capabilities (Strategy)	Capabilities are developed to realise goals	Methodology (capability 2.2.3) supports data innovation (SAF-G4)
Value streams (Strategy)	Value streams show where a goal changes the production chain	Sustainable compliance (SAF-G5) is put into practice in VS-07

SAF goals

ID	Goal	Description	Architectural direction in the SAF
SAF-G1	Cost efficiency and resource sharing	Work as efficiently as possible with limited budgets and growing demand, by sharing services, reusing solutions and pooling resources.	Shared services, reusable and open-source components, modular architectures and step-by-step modernisation.

ID	Goal	Description	Architectural direction in the SAF
SAF-G2	Harmonised reference framework	Provide shared standards, patterns and practices that NSIs adapt locally while staying interoperable.	Common reference models, consistent design principles, and harmonisation as a condition for shared infrastructures and data spaces.
SAF-G3	Modernisation of statistical systems	Move from fragmented legacy environments to modular, service-based architectures that are secure, scalable and maintainable.	Service-based design, risk-based automation, and principles for access control, data protection and accountability where several parties work together.
SAF-G4	Support for data innovation	Bring new data sources, methods and products into production without loss of quality or consistency.	Controlled integration (versioning, validation, automated testing), shared platforms that link innovation and production, and safe reuse of open components.
SAF-G5	Sustainable compliance	Align modernisation with legal, security, quality and ethical frameworks, inside and outside the statistical domain.	Statistical standards (GSBPM, GSIM, SDMX) combined with standards for data management, AI and cloud. Compliance is designed in from the start.

Goal details

SAF-G1 Cost efficiency and resource sharing

Budgets are limited and demand keeps growing. NSIs must therefore work as efficiently as possible. The SAF promotes shared services, reuse of solutions and better interoperability. By pooling resources and using common components, NSIs gain capabilities they could not build alone, and they avoid duplicate work.

The SAF also encourages open-source components and community platforms where they improve transparency, collaboration and cost. Modular architectures and clear governance let NSIs adapt to new needs, shift capacity and modernise step by step, without large reinvestments. Efficiency then supports quality and long-term sustainability instead of competing with them.

SAF-G2 Harmonised reference framework

Without a shared architectural reference, NSIs build isolated solutions. These reduce comparability and raise long-term costs. The SAF offers a common base of standards, patterns and practices. NSIs adapt it to their own context and stay interoperable across borders and domains.

More and more collaboration takes place on shared infrastructures, such as national data platforms and international data spaces. Harmonisation is a condition for taking part. Consistent design principles help NSIs protect the integrity of official statistics, and reuse shared and open solutions safely.

SAF-G3 Modernisation of statistical systems

Many NSIs still depend on fragmented legacy IT that slows down innovation and response. The SAF guides the move to modular, service-based architectures that are secure, scalable and easier to maintain.

Modernisation reduces technical debt, improves reliability and speeds up the delivery of new and better statistics.

Modernisation more often happens in settings with several parties, from national infrastructures to cross-border data spaces. The SAF sets principles for access control, data protection and accountability in those settings. It also takes a risk-based approach to automation and new technology. Critical processes stay tightly governed to protect methodological rigour. Less sensitive steps can be automated or shared.

SAF-G4 Support for data innovation

New data and methods are central to the future of official statistics. Yet many NSIs struggle to introduce a new data source or product. Their production systems are built for predictability and stability. Those qualities are necessary, but they slow down change.

The SAF supports architectures that combine robustness with flexibility. New components, data and workflows can then enter production faster, while quality and compliance stay under control. Versioning, validation and automated testing keep production reliable as it changes. Shared platforms and processes help prototypes move into operational use.

Open source matters here too. NSIs can build on each other's work, which increases transparency and the collective capacity of the community. The SAF supports this with patterns for the safe reuse of open components.

SAF-G5 Sustainable compliance

Compliance with laws, standards and ethical principles underpins the trust in and legitimacy of official statistics. Within the statistical domain, GSBPM, GSIM and SDMX remain the basis for consistent processes, metadata management and data exchange.

Statistical production is now part of a wider data and technology ecosystem. Compliance must therefore extend beyond statistical standards. The SAF encourages the use of relevant standards from data management, artificial intelligence and cloud computing. NSIs then stay interoperable with modern platforms and benefit from progress made elsewhere.

With consistent governance and open, verifiable technology, compliance becomes an enabler instead of a brake. Innovation, data sharing and collaboration take place in controlled and auditable environments. Transparency, scientific rigour and privacy by design are part of every process.

PLACEHOLDER: Goals Template and Application of Goals to be added to the toolkit

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Meaning

The concept

Meaning is the knowledge or interpretation that a concept has in a given context. Meaning answers the question *what does this signify?* Value answers a different question: *what is it worth, and to whom?*

The SAF uses meaning at the level of the framework itself. The meaning elements describe how the statistical community should understand the SAF. Two interpretations matter most. First, the SAF connects strategy and technology. Every technology decision, from a new platform to a redesigned process, can be traced to a strategic objective. Next, the SAF is a common language for the UNECE statistical community. Shared models, practices and principles reduce duplicate work and make collaboration easier. This makes the SAF relevant beyond IT, to statisticians, policy makers and the citizens who depend on reliable statistics and information.

How the SAF applies meaning

Why the SAF records meaning

Architecture frameworks are easily misread. IT staff may see a technical blueprint. Managers may see administrative overhead. Explicit meaning elements set the intended interpretation, so that all stakeholders read the framework in the same way.

How meaning fits into an NSI's own architecture

An NSI uses the meaning elements when it introduces the SAF internally, for example in an architecture charter, an onboarding programme or a management briefing. An NSI may also record what its own core concepts mean, such as "statistical product" or "steady state". That use belongs in the glossary.

Relationships with other concepts

Related concept	Relationship	Example in the SAF
Value (SAF-V)	Meaning explains how value is interpreted	The SAF as common language (SAF-M4) explains why cross-border comparability (SAF-V1) is achievable
Stakeholders (SAF-ST)	Meaning is shaped for and by stakeholders	IT and data professionals (SAF-ST04) read the SAF through its notation (SAF-M4)
Goals (SAF-G)	Meaning frames how goals are understood	The SAF as a foundation for transformation (SAF-M3) frames modernisation (SAF-G3)
Glossary	The meaning of individual terms is recorded in the glossary	The definition of "steady state"

SAF meaning elements

ID	Meaning	Description
SAF-M1	Bridge between strategy and technology	The SAF links strategic objectives, such as relevance and efficiency, to technology choices. IT investments are justified by what they contribute to the mission.
SAF-M2	Catalyst for collaboration	The SAF is a common framework for the statistical community. It makes joint platforms, interoperable systems and harmonised standards possible, and strengthens what UNECE members can do together.
SAF-M3	Foundation for digital transformation	The SAF is more than a set of technical models. It is the basis for digital transformation in official statistics, without loss of methodological rigour or institutional trust.
SAF-M4	Common language and notation	Through TOGAF and ArchiMate, stakeholders share one language and notation. This reduces misunderstanding and raises architectural maturity across the community.

PLACEHOLDER: Meaning Template and Application of Meaning to be added to the toolkit

Outcomes

The concept

An outcome is an end result that has been, or is intended to be, achieved. Outcomes are more concrete than goals. A goal sets a direction. An outcome describes what will be different once that direction has been followed.

Three characteristics set outcomes apart:

- **They are results, not activities.** "Introduce a metadata catalogue" is an activity. "Every registered dataset has complete metadata and lineage" is an outcome.
- **They are measurable, or at least observable.** An outcome without an indicator cannot be used to steer.
- **They are realised by the strategy and architecture layers.** Capabilities, value streams and solutions exist to produce outcomes.

SAF outcomes are technical as well as societal. On the technical side, NSIs gain simpler processes, better metadata management and faster system development. On the societal side, the SAF supports trust, transparency and comparability, which informed policy and public accountability depend on. Outcomes also change over time. As an NSI matures, it sets new targets and adjusts its course.

How the SAF applies outcomes

Why the SAF records outcomes

Outcomes show stakeholders what adopting the framework returns. They connect long-term goals to concrete changes in capabilities, processes and systems. They also make progress measurable, for one NSI and across the community.

How outcomes fit into an NSI's own architecture

An NSI selects the SAF outcomes that match its goals. It defines indicators and target values for its own context, and monitors them in its planning and control cycle. The indicative measures below are examples. The SAF toolkit will offer them as a starting point in SAF-TK-M05.

Relationships with other concepts

Related concept	Relationship	Example in the SAF
Goals (SAF-G)	Outcomes make goals measurable	Improved interoperability (SAF-O3) shows progress on the harmonised reference framework (SAF-G2)
Value (SAF-V)	Outcomes deliver value to stakeholders	Enhanced data quality (SAF-O2) delivers trust and legitimacy (SAF-V6)
Capabilities (Strategy)	Capabilities realise outcomes	Metadata management (capability 2.1.2) realises enhanced data quality (SAF-O2)
Value streams (Strategy)	Value streams produce outcomes in the production chain	The steady-state handovers in VS-01 to VS-06 contribute to improved interoperability (SAF-O3)
Steady states (Business Architecture)	Quality gates make outcomes observable per state	Lineage and metadata requirements per state provide evidence for SAF-O2

SAF outcomes

ID	Outcome	Description	Indicative measures (illustrative)
SAF-O1	Accelerated modernisation	NSIs modernise faster and with less rework, because they start from shared reference models, patterns and building blocks instead of designing from scratch.	Lead time from decision to production for a new statistical product; share of solution designs that reuse SAF building blocks
SAF-O2	Enhanced data quality	Governance, metadata and lineage are part of the architecture. Statistical output therefore meets high standards of quality and reliability. Quality is designed in, not checked afterwards.	Share of datasets with complete metadata and lineage; revision rate of published figures
SAF-O3	Improved interoperability	NSIs reach higher interoperability across systems, domains and borders. This makes international collaboration easier, improves comparability and simplifies the use of external data sources.	Share of data exchanges using standard interfaces (e.g. SDMX); number of components shared between NSIs
SAF-O4	Improved trust and transparency	Openness, security and transparency in the architecture help to build and keep public trust. This strengthens the reputation of NSIs and the legitimacy of their output.	Results of public trust surveys; number of confidentiality or security incidents
SAF-O5	Increased efficiency	Reuse, harmonisation and standardisation reduce duplicate work. The result is lower IT costs, shorter development cycles and more efficient processing.	Number of redundant systems retired; processing time per production cycle; IT cost per statistical product
SAF-O6	Shared knowledge base	A community of practice across UNECE members exchanges lessons learned, reusable components and knowledge. This leads to continuous improvement at lower cost.	Number of reusable components and patterns published; number of NSIs contributing

PLACEHOLDER: Outcome Template and the application of Outcomes to be added to the toolkit

Architecture Principles

The concept

An **architecture principle** is a general rule that guides how an organisation designs, builds and changes its information provision. Principles are durable and rarely change. They apply to all architecture decisions within their scope, not to one project only.

Principles matter in official statistics because production runs in a closely connected environment. A choice in one place affects many others. Principles keep such choices consistent. They also prevent short-term convenience from undermining long-term sustainability, a real risk for NSIs with legacy systems and tight budgets. Finally, principles create accountability. When stakeholders know the principles behind a decision, investments and trade-offs are easier to explain.

TOGAF recommends describing each principle in four parts:

- **Name**: a short, memorable label.
- **Statement**: the rule itself, in one or two sentences.
- **Rationale**: why the rule exists and what it brings.
- **Implications**: what following the rule requires in cost, resources and activities.

The SAF follows this template. A principle is only useful if it is applied. A principle that never changes a decision is a slogan.

How the SAF applies principles

Why the SAF records principles

Principles turn goals into decision rules. When an NSI chooses between technologies, solutions or designs, principles make the choice consistent and explainable. They also give an architecture board a shared basis for reviewing projects.

How principles fit into an NSI's own architecture

An NSI takes the SAF principles into its own principle set, adapts the wording to national policy where needed, and adds national principles. Principles only take effect when they are part of governance. Architecture reviews test compliance, and deviations follow a documented dispensation process. The business layer of the SAF shows how each value stream applies the principles.

Relationships with other concepts

Related concept	Relationship	Example in the SAF
Goals (SAF-G)	Principles guide how goals are pursued	Loose coupling (SAF-P07) guides modernisation (SAF-G3)
Drivers (SAF-D)	Drivers explain why a principle exists	Trust and data protection (SAF-D3) explain privacy by design (SAF-P11)
Requirements (SAF-REQ) **[R5]**	Principles are refined into concrete requirements	SAF-P09 becomes the minimum metadata set of each steady state
Steady states (Business Architecture)	Principles shape the design rules of the steady-state model	SAF-P07, P08, P09 and P11 underpin the six design rules
Value streams (Business Architecture)	Each value stream applies a subset of the principles	VS-07 enforces SAF-P09, P10 and P11 across the chain

SAF architecture principles

ID	Principle	Statement
SAF-P01	Reuse before open source, open source before buying, buying before building	When options are equally suitable, reuse comes before open source, open source before purchase, and purchase before own development.
SAF-P02	Active support	Systems have an active user community or vendor support. As a rule of thumb, the latest or second-to-last major version is used.
SAF-P03	Active life cycle management	Systems and components are kept up to date according to an agreed life cycle management policy.
SAF-P04	Maximise the benefits for the organisation	IT decisions maximise the benefit for the organisation as a whole.
SAF-P05	IT and technology is everyone's business	All parts of the organisation take part in the IT decisions needed to reach organisational goals.
SAF-P06	Business continuity	Work continues despite system or staff outages.
SAF-P07	Implement loosely coupled processes and systems	Processes and systems are built as independently as possible and share functionality through standard interfaces.
SAF-P08	Data is shared property	Statistical data that adds value for internal or external users is shared.
SAF-P09	No data without metadata and classification	All shared data has metadata describing its content and meaning.
SAF-P10	Security by design	Security is an integral part of solutions across all layers of the architecture.
SAF-P11	Privacy by design	Privacy is an integral part of system architecture and business processes.

Principle details

SAF-P01 Reuse before open source, open source before buying, buying before building

- *Statement.* When options are equally suitable according to the business case, reuse of (parts of) existing applications comes first. Open-source software comes before purchase, and purchase comes before own development. Non-statistical processes use standard applications only.
- *Rationale.* Reuse is sustainable and cost-efficient, and it leads to standardisation of services and information provision. Open source increases transparency and avoids vendor lock-in.
- *Implications.* Each solution choice records the options considered, in this order. Own development requires explicit justification. Reusable components must be easy to find, for example in a shared catalogue.

SAF-P02 Active support

- *Statement.* Hardware and software have an active user community or vendor support. As a rule of thumb, the latest or second-to-last major version is used.

- *Rationale.* Business continuity requires fast and competent support when something breaks. Security requires that known vulnerabilities are fixed in time.
- *Implications.* Support status is a selection criterion for every component. Components that approach end of support are flagged in the life cycle plan.

SAF-P03 Active life cycle management

- *Statement.* Systems and components are kept up to date according to an agreed life cycle management (LCM) policy.
- *Rationale.* Without LCM, systems become outdated and vulnerable, and technical debt builds up. Paying off that debt later takes disproportionate effort and creates continuity risks.
- *Implications.* Every component has an owner and a life cycle plan. LCM has a structural budget, not only when problems arise.

SAF-P04 Maximise the benefits for the organisation

- *Statement.* IT decisions maximise the benefit for the organisation as a whole.
- *Rationale.* Decisions taken from an organisation-wide view have more long-term value than decisions taken from a departmental view. The principle stands for "service above self".
- *Implications.* Local optimisations need justification against organisation-wide priorities. Shared solutions are preferred over departmental ones, even when they fit one department less well.

SAF-P05 IT and technology is everyone's business

- *Statement.* All parts of the organisation take part in the IT decisions needed to reach organisational goals.
- *Rationale.* The users of IT are its main stakeholders. IT only fits the business when business experts and technical staff set goals and objectives together.
- *Implications.* Business ownership of each information system is assigned explicitly. Architecture and change decisions are taken in joint business and IT forums.

SAF-P06 Business continuity

- *Statement.* Work continues despite system or staff outages.
- *Rationale.* The more an NSI depends on its systems, the more their reliability matters. Hardware failures, disasters and data corruption must not stop statistical production or release.
- *Implications.* Continuity requirements are part of every design. Critical processes have fallback arrangements, and recovery is tested regularly.

SAF-P07 Implement loosely coupled processes and systems

- *Statement.* Processes and systems are built as independently as possible. They share functionality and logic through standard interfaces.
- *Rationale.* Loose coupling makes it easier to change or replace a single process or system. It also improves scalability and robustness, and it makes different security and privacy requirements easier to enforce.
- *Implications.* Domains exchange data through defined interfaces, such as the steady-state handovers in the business architecture. Direct dependencies on another domain's internal data or logic are avoided.

SAF-P08 Data is shared property

- *Statement.* Statistical data that adds value for internal or external users is shared.
- *Rationale.* Sharing enables reuse. In data collection, reuse reduces response burden. In processing, it avoids duplicate work on cleaning and analysing data.
- *Implications.* Data is registered and findable in a catalogue. Before new data is collected, reuse of existing data is checked. Access is governed, not withheld by default.

SAF-P09 No data without metadata and classification

- *Statement.* All shared data has metadata that describes its content and meaning as well as possible, and an AIC classification (availability, integrity, confidentiality).
- *Rationale.* Metadata makes data FAIR. An AIC classification sets the technical and organisational measures that laws, regulations and security standards require.

- *Implications.* Metadata and classification are recorded when data is registered, not afterwards. Data without the required metadata is not handed over.

SAF-P10 Security by design

- *Statement.* Security is an integral part of every solution. Security mechanisms are consistent across all layers of the architecture and scale from small to large objects.
- *Rationale.* Security added afterwards costs more, works less well and leaves gaps between layers.
- *Implications.* Security requirements are set in the design phase of every solution and tested before production.

SAF-P11 Privacy by design

- *Statement.* Privacy is an integral part of system architecture and business processes.
- *Rationale.* Privacy added afterwards conflicts with functionality and leaves risks. Built in from the start, it becomes part of the core functionality without limiting it.
- *Implications.* Privacy impact is assessed in the design phase. Measures such as pseudonymisation, data minimisation and disclosure control are placed at defined points in the value chain.

PLACEHOLDER: Principles Template and the application of Principles to be added to the toolkit

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Value

The concept

Value is the worth, usefulness or importance of something to a stakeholder. Value is always value *for someone*. The same outcome can be worth a lot to one stakeholder and little to another.

Value differs from the other motivation elements:

- An outcome is a result. Value is what that result is worth to a stakeholder.
- A goal is an intention of the organisation. Value is the reason a stakeholder cares whether the goal is reached.
- Meaning is how something is interpreted. Value is how much it is worth.

The SAF creates value at several levels. For NSIs, it means lower risk, more agility and better alignment between IT and business. For international organisations, it means harmonisation and comparability. For citizens and policy makers, it means statistics they can rely on. Value also has a time dimension. Without a framework, modernisation tends to be fragmented, costly and short-lived. The SAF gives a stable base that reduces technical debt and makes investments last.

How the SAF applies value

Why the SAF records value

Value makes the case for architecture in terms that stakeholders recognise. Architecture competes with other priorities for money and attention. It only gets support when its long-term worth is clear.

How value fits into an NSI's own architecture

An NSI uses the SAF value elements to build the business case for architecture work: in investment proposals, annual reports and briefings for its ministry or board. It selects the values that matter to its key stakeholders and links them to the outcomes it measures.

Relationships with other concepts

Related concept	Relationship	Example in the SAF
Stakeholders (SAF-ST)	Stakeholders perceive value	Policy makers (SAF-ST03) value trust and legitimacy (SAF-V6)

Related concept	Relationship	Example in the SAF
Outcomes (SAF-O)	Outcomes deliver value	Improved interoperability (SAF-O3) delivers cross-border comparability (SAF-V1)
Meaning (SAF-M)	Meaning explains how value is interpreted	The SAF as bridge between strategy and technology (SAF-M1) underpins strategic alignment (SAF-V4)
Value streams (Strategy)	Value streams create value for stakeholders, stage by stage	VS-06 delivers released statistics to users and society

SAF value elements

ID	Value	Description
SAF-V1	Cross-border comparability	Statistics are worth more when they can be compared across borders. Common standards, models and processes make that comparison meaningful.
SAF-V2	Innovation enablement	The SAF lowers the barriers for AI, machine learning, real-time analytics and big data. NSIs can experiment safely and keep their methods sound.
SAF-V3	Risk reduction	Compliance, security and governance are built into the architecture. This reduces the risk of system failures, data breaches and regulatory non-compliance, and protects the trust of citizens and stakeholders.
SAF-V4	Strategic alignment	IT initiatives contribute directly to the mission of producing official statistics. This improves governance, prioritisation and the impact of IT investments.
SAF-V5	Sustainability	Efficient, modern architectures with less technical debt give NSIs a clear path forward, without repeated and costly overhauls.
SAF-V6	Trust and legitimacy	Transparency, ethical practice and robust security strengthen the position of NSIs as authoritative providers of public data.

PLACEHOLDER: Value Template and the application of Values to be added to the toolkit

Assessment

The concept

An assessment is the result of analysing a driver for one specific organisation. It records what the driver means for that organisation: a strength, a weakness, an opportunity or a threat. A driver describes a force.

An assessment describes how that force affects this NSI, today.

Three characteristics set assessments apart:

- **They are specific to one organisation.** "Resource constraints" is a driver for many NSIs. "Two thirds of our processing runs on platforms out of vendor support" is an assessment for one NSI.
- **They are based on evidence.** An assessment rests on facts, such as an application portfolio scan, an audit finding, a maturity assessment or a staff survey. An opinion without evidence is not an assessment.
- **They change over time.** A driver often stays the same for years. An assessment changes as the NSI acts on it. It is therefore reviewed regularly, for example once a year.

The SAF does not define assessments. A generic assessment would contradict the concept itself. This section explains how assessments are used, and the toolkit provides a template to record them.

How the SAF applies assessments

Why the SAF uses assessments

Assessments are the link between the generic SAF drivers and the goals of an NSI. Without them, an NSI jumps from "the world is changing" straight to "we must modernise", and nobody can see why this particular goal has priority. An assessment makes that step explicit. It also gives a baseline: if the next assessment of the same driver is better, the NSI can show progress.

How assessments fit into an NSI's own architecture

An NSI writes one or more assessments for each driver it recognises. The second step of applying drivers, *Assess*, produces them (see *Drivers*). A SWOT analysis is a common format: each finding is recorded as a strength, weakness, opportunity or threat. Assessments then feed the third step, *Respond*, in which the NSI derives or confirms its goals. In TOGAF terms, assessments are part of Phase A, Architecture Vision, and of the baseline description of each architecture domain.

Relationships with other concepts

Related concept	Relationship	Example
Drivers (SAF-D)	An assessment analyses a driver for one NSI	An assessment of SAF-D5 records the share of platforms out of vendor support
Stakeholders (SAF-ST)	Stakeholders contribute evidence and recognise the findings	CIOs and CTOs (SAF-ST01) own the assessment of the application portfolio
Goals (SAF-G)	Assessments influence which goals an NSI sets and how it prioritises them	A weakness on SAF-D5 makes modernisation (SAF-G3) a priority
Outcomes (SAF-O)	A new assessment shows whether outcomes have been reached	The share of unsupported platforms falls after a modernisation programme (SAF-O1)
Capability Model (Strategy)	A capability maturity assessment is a structured form of assessment	A low score on metadata management (capability 2.1.2)

Examples (illustrative)

The examples show the form of an assessment and its links. They are not SAF assessments and do not apply to every NSI.

Driver	Assessment	Type	Evidence	Leads to
SAF-D5 Resource constraints and organisational agility	Two thirds of our processing runs on platforms that are out of vendor support	Weakness	Application portfolio scan	Priority for SAF-G3 Modernisation of statistical systems
SAF-D1 Evolving data ecosystems and partnerships	A national data space is being set up, and our NSI is invited to join as a participant	Opportunity	Government programme plan	Priority for SAF-G2 Harmonised reference framework
SAF-D3 Trust, scientific rigour and data protection	We cannot show, for each published figure, which source data version it is based on	Weakness	Internal audit finding	Priority for SAF-O2 Enhanced data quality (lineage)

PLACEHOLDER: Assessment Template and the application of Assessments to be added to the toolkit

Requirements

The concept

A requirement is a statement of need that a solution must meet. A goal says what the NSI wants to achieve. A requirement says what a specific solution, process or platform must do or provide to contribute to that goal.

Three characteristics set requirements apart:

- **They apply to a specific solution.** "Modernise statistical systems" is a goal. "The new processing platform records the lineage of every registered dataset" is a requirement.
- **They are testable.** It must be possible to check whether a solution meets the requirement, for example in an architecture review or an acceptance test.
- **They are derived, not invented.** A good requirement can be traced to a goal, an outcome or a principle. A requirement without that trace needs a justification.

The SAF does not define requirements for NSIs. Requirements depend on the solution, the context and the maturity of each NSI. This section explains how requirements relate to the other motivation elements. The toolkit provides a template to derive and record them.

How the SAF applies requirements

Why the SAF uses requirements

Principles and goals are deliberately general. They only change a design when they are made concrete. Requirements are that concrete form. They connect the motivation layer to the architecture domains, and they let an architecture board test whether a solution really contributes to the goals it claims to serve.

How requirements fit into an NSI's own architecture

In TOGAF, requirements are managed in Requirements Management, at the centre of the ADM. They are identified in every phase and checked against each architecture decision. An NSI derives its requirements from three sources:

1. **Goals and outcomes.** What must the solution provide to contribute to a goal, and how will the outcome be measured?

2. **Principles.** What does each relevant SAF principle mean for this solution?
3. **SAF reference content.** Which SAF building blocks apply, and what do they require?

The SAF already contains content that works as a set of requirements. The steady states in the business architecture each have quality criteria and a minimum metadata set. An NSI that adopts the steady-state model can use these directly as requirements for the processes and platforms that produce and store each state. The same applies to the principle tables in each value stream. They show which principles apply at which stage of the production chain.

Relationships with other concepts

Related concept	Relationship	Example
Goals (SAF-G)	Requirements make goals concrete for a solution	SAF-G4 Support for data innovation leads to a requirement for automated testing in the production pipeline
Outcomes (SAF-O)	Requirements contribute to outcomes and make them measurable in a solution	Lineage recording contributes to SAF-O2 Enhanced data quality
Principles (SAF-P)	Requirements apply principles to a specific solution	SAF-P09 becomes the requirement that no dataset is handed over without its minimum metadata
Constraints	Requirements describe what a solution must do; constraints limit how it may be done	A requirement for scalable processing within the constraint that data stays on premises
Steady states (Business Architecture)	Quality criteria and minimum metadata per state work as reusable requirements	The criteria for registering data in State #1 Raw Data

Examples (illustrative)

The examples show how a requirement is derived and traced. They are not SAF requirements.

Source	Requirement	Applies to	How to verify
SAF-P09 No data without metadata and classification	No dataset is registered in a steady state without its minimum metadata set and an AIC classification	Data catalogue and registration process	Registration is refused when mandatory metadata is missing
SAF-G4 Support for data innovation	A new method can move from the innovation environment to production without manual re-implementation	Analytical platform and deployment pipeline	Time and effort for one pilot method to reach production
SAF-P07 Implement loosely coupled processes and systems	Business domains exchange data only through registered steady states, not through each other's internal data	All production processes	Architecture review of data flows between domains

PLACEHOLDER: Requirements Template and the application of Requirements to be added to the toolkit

Constraints

The concept

A constraint is a factor that limits how goals can be realised. A requirement describes what a solution must do. A constraint describes the boundaries within which it must be done. Constraints are usually not chosen by the architect. They are given by law, policy, budget, existing contracts or the current landscape.

Three characteristics set constraints apart:

- **They limit the solution space.** A constraint rules out options. "Personal data may not be processed outside the EU" excludes certain cloud services, whatever their other merits.
- **They come from outside the design.** Typical sources are legislation, government policy, budget, staffing, existing contracts and technical dependencies.
- **They differ in how fixed they are.** A legal constraint cannot be negotiated. A budget or policy constraint may change. Recording the source of a constraint shows which ones can be challenged.

This section is about constraints on an NSI's own architecture. It is different from the *Constraints & Assumptions* in the Introduction, which describe the boundaries of the SAF itself (for example SAF-C1 and SAF-C2).

The SAF does not define constraints for NSIs, because legal and organisational contexts differ. Some constraints, however, apply to almost every NSI, such as data protection law and the statistical confidentiality required by national statistical law. They are used below as examples.

How the SAF applies constraints

Why the SAF uses constraints

Constraints that stay implicit cause late surprises. A design that looks right fails in a procurement, a privacy assessment or a security review, because a limit was not known in time. Recording constraints early, and linking them to the goals they affect, keeps the architecture realistic. It also makes trade-offs visible: when a constraint blocks a goal, the board can decide whether to accept that or to challenge the constraint.

How constraints fit into an NSI's own architecture

In TOGAF, constraints are identified in Phase A, Architecture Vision, and managed together with requirements in Requirements Management. An NSI records its constraints with their source and whether they are fixed or negotiable. Each constraint is linked to the goals, requirements or solutions it affects. Constraints are reviewed when their source changes, for example after new legislation or a new government policy on cloud use.

Several parts of the SAF help to identify constraints. *Definition of Scope* states that the SAF does not prescribe a technology stack or organisational design, so those choices are left to the NSI and its constraints. The principles on security and privacy by design (SAF-P10 and SAF-P11) point to the legal and security frameworks that usually impose constraints.

Relationships with other concepts

Related concept	Relationship	Example
Drivers (SAF-D)	Some drivers are the origin of constraints	SAF-D3 Trust, scientific rigour and data protection is the origin of data protection constraints
Goals (SAF-G)	Constraints limit how goals can be realised	A ban on public cloud for statistical microdata limits how SAF-G3 Modernisation is realised

Related concept	Relationship	Example
Requirements	Constraints bound the solutions that can meet a requirement	A scalability requirement must be met within on-premises infrastructure
Principles (SAF-P)	Principles are applied within the limits that constraints set	SAF-P01 Reuse before buying applies within public procurement rules
Stakeholders (SAF-ST)	Stakeholders often own or impose constraints	A privacy officer applies data protection law; a ministry sets the budget

Examples (illustrative)

The examples show the form of a constraint. They are not SAF constraints, and their content differs per country.

Constraint	Source	Fixed or negotiable	Affects
Statistical microdata is processed only within the NSI's own controlled environment	National statistical law and confidentiality policy	Fixed	Platform and hosting choices for SAF-G3; data sharing under SAF-G2
Personal data is processed in line with the GDPR, including data minimisation and purpose limitation	EU legislation	Fixed	Design of data acquisition and standardisation; SAF-P11 Privacy by design
Public cloud services are used only for business support functions, not for statistical production	Government or NSI cloud policy	Negotiable	Technology choices for SAF-G3 and SAF-G4

PLACEHOLDER: Constraints Template and the application of Constraints to be added to the toolkit

Stakeholders

The concept

A **stakeholder** is an individual, group or organisation with an interest in the effects of the architecture [**R8**]. Stakeholders have *concerns*: questions or interests they want the architecture to address, such as cost, risk, quality or compliance.

A stakeholder is not the same as a business actor or role. An actor or role performs work in the architecture, for example a data steward who registers datasets. A stakeholder has an interest in the architecture, whether or not it performs work in it. The same person or organisation can be both.

SAF stakeholders range from CIOs and technical experts within NSIs to international organisations, policy makers, researchers and society as a whole. Their interests differ, and the framework has to balance them. IT professionals turn SAF principles into systems. Policy makers care about the results those systems make possible. UNECE keeps the SAF harmonised and relevant across countries.

How the SAF applies stakeholders

Why the SAF records stakeholders

Architecture is never developed in isolation. Knowing the stakeholders makes clear whose concerns the architecture must address, who should take part in governance and decisions, and which views each audience needs. Involvement also builds support. People who take part in architecture decisions are more likely to back them.

How stakeholders fit into an NSI's own architecture

An NSI maps the SAF stakeholders onto its own stakeholder landscape. It identifies who represents each stakeholder and records their concerns. The concerns determine which views the NSI produces. A CIO needs a capability and investment view. A privacy officer needs a view of data flows and protection measures. The stakeholder map is reviewed at the start of each architecture cycle.

Relationships with other concepts

Related concept	Relationship	Example in the SAF
Drivers (SAF-D)	Stakeholders have concerns about drivers and raise them	CIOs and CTOs (SAF-ST01) raise resource constraints (SAF-D5)
Goals (SAF-G)	Stakeholders own goals	NSIs (SAF-ST05) own modernisation (SAF-G3)
Value (SAF-V)	Stakeholders perceive value	Researchers and academia (SAF-ST06) value innovation enablement (SAF-V2)
Viewpoints	Stakeholder concerns determine which views are produced	Privacy officers need data-flow and protection views
Business actors and roles (Business Architecture)	A stakeholder may also act in the architecture	Data providers are stakeholders and actors in VS-01

SAF stakeholders

ID	Stakeholder	Category	Key concerns	What the SAF offers
SAF-ST01	CIOs and CTOs of NSIs	Within the NSI	Strategic IT investment, alignment of IT with business goals, compliance	A framework to compare options, align IT with business goals and show compliance with international standards
SAF-ST02	Citizens and society	Society	Trustworthy, transparent and modern statistics	Statistics that support democratic accountability and informed public debate
SAF-ST03	Government policy makers	Society	Timely, accurate and comparable data in accessible formats	Better statistical production and dissemination (indirect benefit)
SAF-ST04	IT and data professionals	Within the NSI	Common patterns, tools and practices; collaboration across institutions	Shared patterns and practices that save effort and shorten the learning curve

ID	Stakeholder	Category	Key concerns	What the SAF offers
SAF-ST05	National Statistical Institutes (NSIs)	Statistical community	Structured guidance for enterprise architecture; efficiency; quality	Guidance tailored to official statistics and aligned with international practice
SAF-ST06	Researchers and academia	Society	Access to high-quality data and metadata for research	Systems designed for openness, data sharing and rich metadata
SAF-ST07	UNECE and other international bodies	Statistical community	Relevance, coherence and adoption of the framework	A custodial role for UNECE; alignment with the modernisation work of Eurostat and the UN Statistics Division